fort. There's also subsidised IVF support in the offing.

More children signifying economic security is what typifies poverty and low development globally. Prosperity and progress usually thin family sizes. Why, then, is Andhra inverting the equation? That too under a CM who's an exemplar of 1980s-style family planning? For, Naidu has just one child—43-year-old Telugu Desam Party scion Nara Lokesh, who, too, in turn, has just one son.

WHY THE REVERSAL

Call it too much progress. The state's total fertility rate (TFR) has dropped to 1.5 (2022-23) from 3 (1992-93). That's below 2.1, the minimum replacement level. The decimal point above two implies childbirths per women in a demographic set more than balances out mortalities, keeping a population stable. A TFR below 1.5 is a "rich nation's crisis", with Japan (1.2), South Korea (0.7) and Italy (1.2) leading the demographic plunge. India, too, is tapering off at 1.9. But then, it can afford to be there. In Andhra, even the district with the highest fertility rate, Kadapa, weighs in only at 1.99. Mothers in Visakhapatnam birth the nadir: 1.32. If this trend holds, Andhra's TFR will fall to 1.07 by 2051.

Takeaways

- **Naidu urges people of AP to have more babies**
- **Policy offers an array of cash incentives**
- **Plan to reverse fertility rate, now plunged to 1.5**

After a point, a low TFR hits productivity. In a decade, 19 per cent of AP's population will be 60-plus. Bihar will still be at 10.9 per cent then, and Uttar Pradesh at 11.8 per cent. In Andhra, below-35s will plunge to 43.2 per cent by then, underscoring the crisis it faces.

"A vibrant economy is fuelled by a young workforce," says Dr Chander Shekhar, an authority in fertility and social demography at Mumbai's International Institute for Population Sciences. "So, a reduction in numbers impacts a state's growth. It could also lead to more inward migration of labour."

While an unsaid part of the problem, working class in-migration from poorer eastern and northern states could be adding to Andhra's anxieties. "If population decline continues, even white-collar jobs in IT, AI, pharma and biotech could increasingly go to outsiders," says Samayam Hemanth Kumar, president of the Andhra Pradesh Unemployed Joint Action Committee.

The southern states tamed the population genie not coercively, but by embedding it within a human-led matrix of education and health. Of late, it's being seen as too much of a runaway success. In Tamil Nadu, which has an even lower TFR than Andhra's at 1.3, ex-CM M.K. Stalin was only half-joking when he encouraged "newlyweds to bear children as early as possible... since the number of MPs depends on our population". Naidu may deny his new policy has anything to do with delimitation, but that ambient scare is real.

His U-turn has led to its own complications. The VHP wants the incentives to be given to only Hindu families. Poonam Muttreja, executive director, Population Fund of India, looks askance at another aspect. "It's personal choice. Women must have 100 per cent agency here. Any attempt to influence this, even with financial aid, infringes on their rights." Other experts wonder if Andhra Pradesh can pull it off where even Japan and China failed. ■

▶ WEST BENGAL

Iron Man, Remade in Bengal

Suvendu gets off the blocks with tough measures, says no violator will be spared as the "rule of law" returns

By **Arkamoy Datta Majumdar**

IT HASN'T TAKEN LONG FOR THE SUVENDU ADHIKARI imprint to be felt on the visible—and audible—parts of governance in West Bengal. Days into office, the new chief minister is sending out a clear message. The way he describes it, the era of "ruler's law" is over, and "rule of law" is back—wrought in iron. From riots to post-poll violence, and restrictions on street gatherings, loudspeakers as well as alleged illegal slaughterhouses, an array of high-octane issues saw speeches from the CM, all delivered in a hard, magisterial tone. Action followed.



ANI

CITIZENS' FORUM Suvendu Adhikari interacts with people at a *janata darbar*, Kolkata, May 25